



Cultural duality: A glimpse of Colombo's contrasts, from a vintage collage of a celebrity cricket match at the P. Sara Oval featuring Nargis to the calm waters of Beira Lake seen from the Seema Malaka Temple. PICS: LAVANYA LAKSHMINARAYANAN

as a casual stroll soon turned into a two-hour gastronomic marathon, and a stomach with absolutely no room left.

The Diary's World Cup stint spanned three India matches, all defeats, one in Indore and two in the port city of Visakhapatnam. Yet, it wasn't the cricketing highs or the culinary delights that will linger longest in memory. It was a five-minute exchange with Bangladesh pacer Marufa Akter that etched itself most deeply into the Diary's pages. An interview with Marufa, conducted earlier in Colombo, had already appeared in Sportstar by the time she flew to India. When the Diary found a quiet moment to hand her a copy of the magazine, the 20-year-old's radiant smile on seeing it felt like the best review one could ever hope for.

Anirudh Velamuri

A city of memories, missing a few

After much coaxing from every tuk-tuk driver the Diary employed for its stadium runs, a day was finally set aside to explore Colombo. The

Enduring echo: A billboard of the late Zubeen Garg stands tall in Guwahati, his voice and presence still woven into the city's everyday rhythm. RAJDEEP SAHA

six-hour sightseeing expedition began at the iconic P. Sara Oval, which incidentally now serves as the home base of the national women's team and its developmental pathways.

Tucked away in Borella, a neighbourhood that has historically borne the brunt of the city's riots, the venue, home to the Tamil Union Cricket Club, was among the structures burnt down during the anti-Tamil violence of 1983. The premises, as the Diary's car guide later revealed, house cricket memorabilia from Sir Donald Bradman's visit to the island. Funnily enough, the only visible female representation on its walls was a

framed collage from a celebrity cricket match featuring Bollywood veterans of the 1950s, including Raj Kapoor and Nargis.

More than the heavily Instagrammed and crowded Gangaramaya Temple, the Diary found peace in the quiet Seema Malaka Temple just a few hundred metres away. The structure itself stands as a symbol of Colombo's inter-religious harmony; its reconstruction on the Beira Lake was funded by a Muslim businessman and designed by the legendary Lankan architect Geoffrey Bawa.

The World Cup run in Sri Lanka has been underwhelming, marred by washouts, lacklustre promotion, and

